

A friendly reminder: AI usage has an environmental cost

Posted by u/slaphead_jr • 0 points • 10 comments

Hello everyone,

While I've genuinely enjoyed the recent trend of people generating images based on their usernames or interactions, I think it's also worth taking a moment to reflect on the environmental cost of these seemingly harmless prompts.

According to a study led by Hugging Face and Carnegie Mellon University, generating a single image with AI consumes roughly as much energy as fully charging your smartphone. In comparison, generating 1,000 text prompts uses only about 16% of a single phone charge.

This isn't a call to stop using these tools. I totally get the excitement, I use them too. But in a world where urgency around climate action seems to be slipping further out of focus, I believe it's up to us as individuals to make more conscious choices, even in the digital realm.

So maybe next time you're about to run 20 variations of an image prompt just for fun, take a second to ask: do I really need all of these?

Here's the article if you'd like to dig into the research:

 [MIT Tech Review – Every AI image has a carbon cost]()

Let's keep having fun, but let's stay mindful too :)

Comments

u/ThatNorthernHag • -1 points • 2025-03-25 10:33 UTC

You are seriously misinformed and you should ask some AI what is the truth about this.

u/slaphead_jr • 2 points • 2025-03-25 12:48 UTC

presuming this is a joke: haha

u/Guru_warrior • 0 points • 2025-03-25 09:17 UTC

GPT's response to the carbon cost of a prompt...

'The carbon cost of sending a short GPT prompt is very low, but not zero. Here's a rough breakdown:

Estimated Carbon Footprint

- A short GPT-4 prompt and response (text only) is estimated to emit 0.001 to 0.01 grams of CO₂e.
- To put that in context:
- 1 Google search emits around 0.2 grams CO₂e
- 1 email (no attachment) emits about 4 grams CO₂e
- So using GPT for a quick text exchange is significantly less impactful than many other common digital actions.

Why it's so low

- GPT inference (answering your question) is relatively efficient compared to training.
- Most emissions from LLMs come from training the model, not using it.
- Usage emissions depend on the data center's energy efficiency and whether it uses renewable energy (OpenAI uses Microsoft Azure, which aims to be carbon negative by 2030).

Bottom line

Sending a short prompt is like breathing out once—negligible carbon, but it adds up at scale. Individually, your footprint from using ChatGPT lightly is minimal.'

Very different to when you ask Grok's unhinged the same question 🤪 Well worth asking haha

u/Embarrassed_Egg2711 • 1 points • 2025-03-25 13:43 UTC

ChatGPT does not have the capability to reliably or accurately evaluate the carbon footprint it generates.

u/Sure-Drive-6613 • 5 points • 2025-03-25 09:01 UTC

Now imagine if "mining" a fake currency cost even more

u/420LongDong69 • -2 points • 2025-03-25 09:15 UTC

Why fake tho

u/Embarrassed_Egg2711 • 2 points • 2025-03-25 13:42 UTC

Because "real" currencies are minted, not mined.

Crypto securities are not real currencies.

u/420LongDong69 • 0 points • 2025-03-26 18:20 UTC

FIAT currency is 99% digital, 1 % is actually printed. I assume you refer to FIAT as you say "real". Currency also is a term not defined by you
Imao

u/wayanonforthis • 6 points • 2025-03-25 08:48 UTC

I don't have a car, kids and taken 1 flight in the past 5 years, I think my conscience is ok but I take your point.

u/AutoModerator • 1 points • 2025-03-25 08:42 UTC

Hey /u/slaphead_jr!

If your post is a screenshot of a ChatGPT conversation, please reply to this message with the [conversation link](<https://help.openai.com/en/articles/7925741-chatgpt-shared-links-faq>) or prompt.

If your post is a DALL-E 3 image post, please reply with the prompt used to make this image.

Consider joining our [public discord server](<https://discord.gg/hT6Pxe8gdZ>)! We have free bots with GPT-4 (with vision), image generators, and more!

🤖

Note: For any ChatGPT-related concerns, email support@openai.com

I am a bot, and this action was performed automatically. Please [contact the moderators of this subreddit](</message/compose/?to=/r/ChatGPT>) if you have any questions or concerns.